

Classic Tales

Birbal's Khichdi

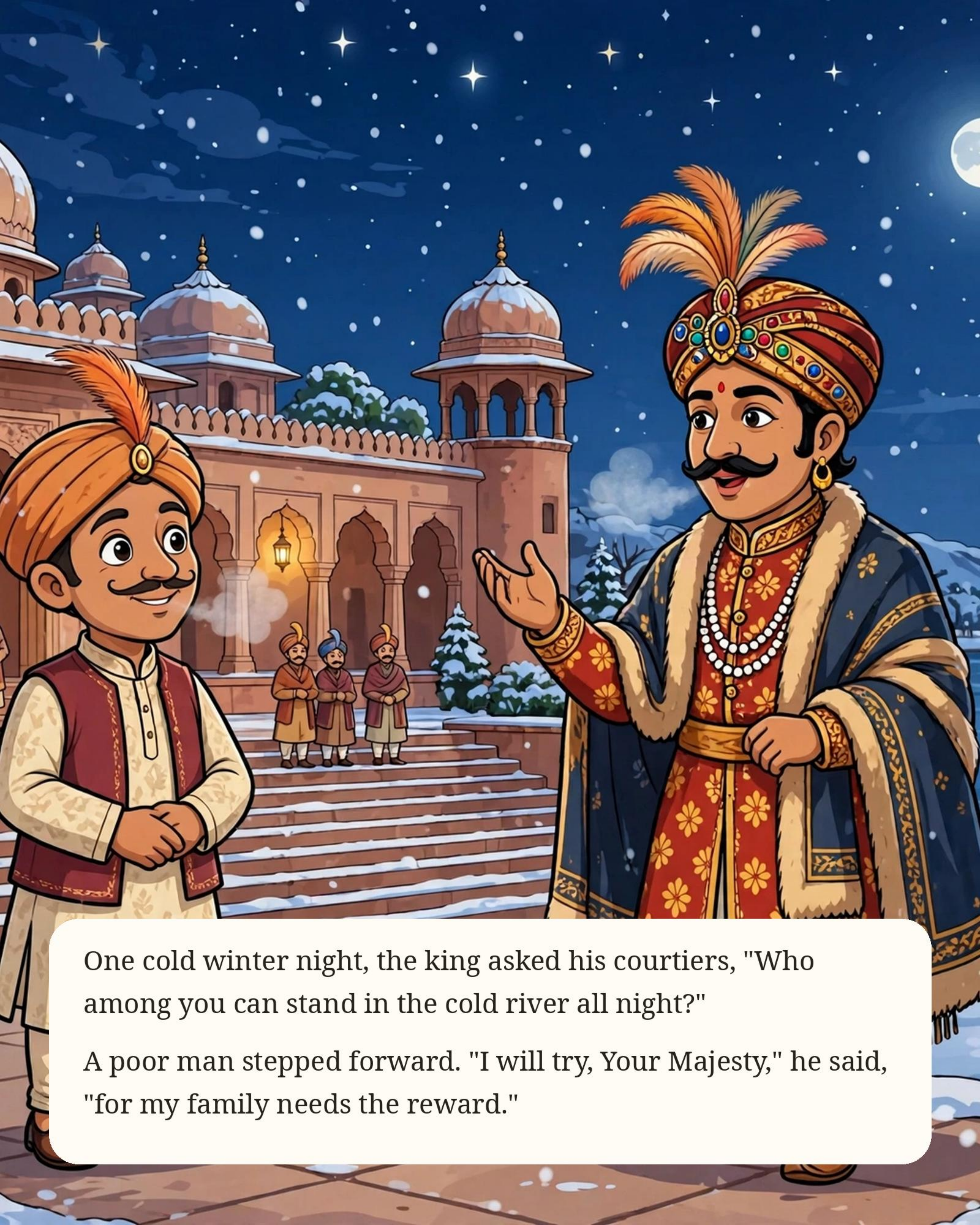


KIDS BOOK VIDEOS



Long, long ago in India, there lived a great king named Akbar.
His court was full of wise men.

The wisest of them all was Birbal. He could solve any puzzle
with a smile.



One cold winter night, the king asked his courtiers, "Who among you can stand in the cold river all night?"

A poor man stepped forward. "I will try, Your Majesty," he said, "for my family needs the reward."



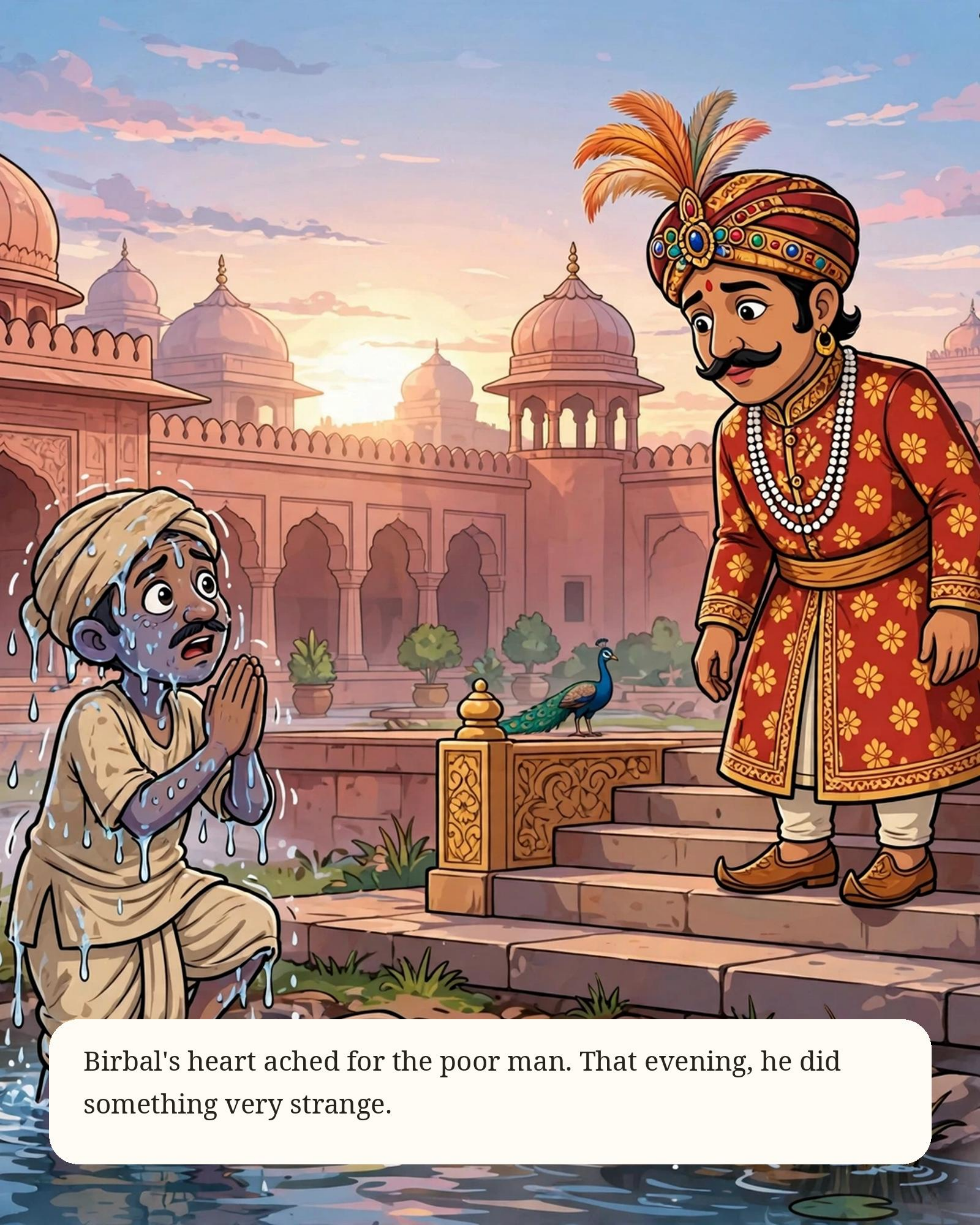
All night the poor man stood shivering in the icy water. In the morning, he climbed out, blue with cold.

"I did it, Your Majesty!" he cried. "Now may I have the reward you promised?"



But the king shook his head. "How did you stay warm?" he asked. "I saw a lamp burning far away on the palace wall," said the poor man. "Its little light gave me courage."

"Then the lamp kept you warm!" laughed the king. "No reward for you!" And the poor man went home, sad and empty-handed.



Birbal's heart ached for the poor man. That evening, he did something very strange.



He tied a pot of khichdi — rice and lentils — to a tall, tall pole, a hundred feet away from a small fire.



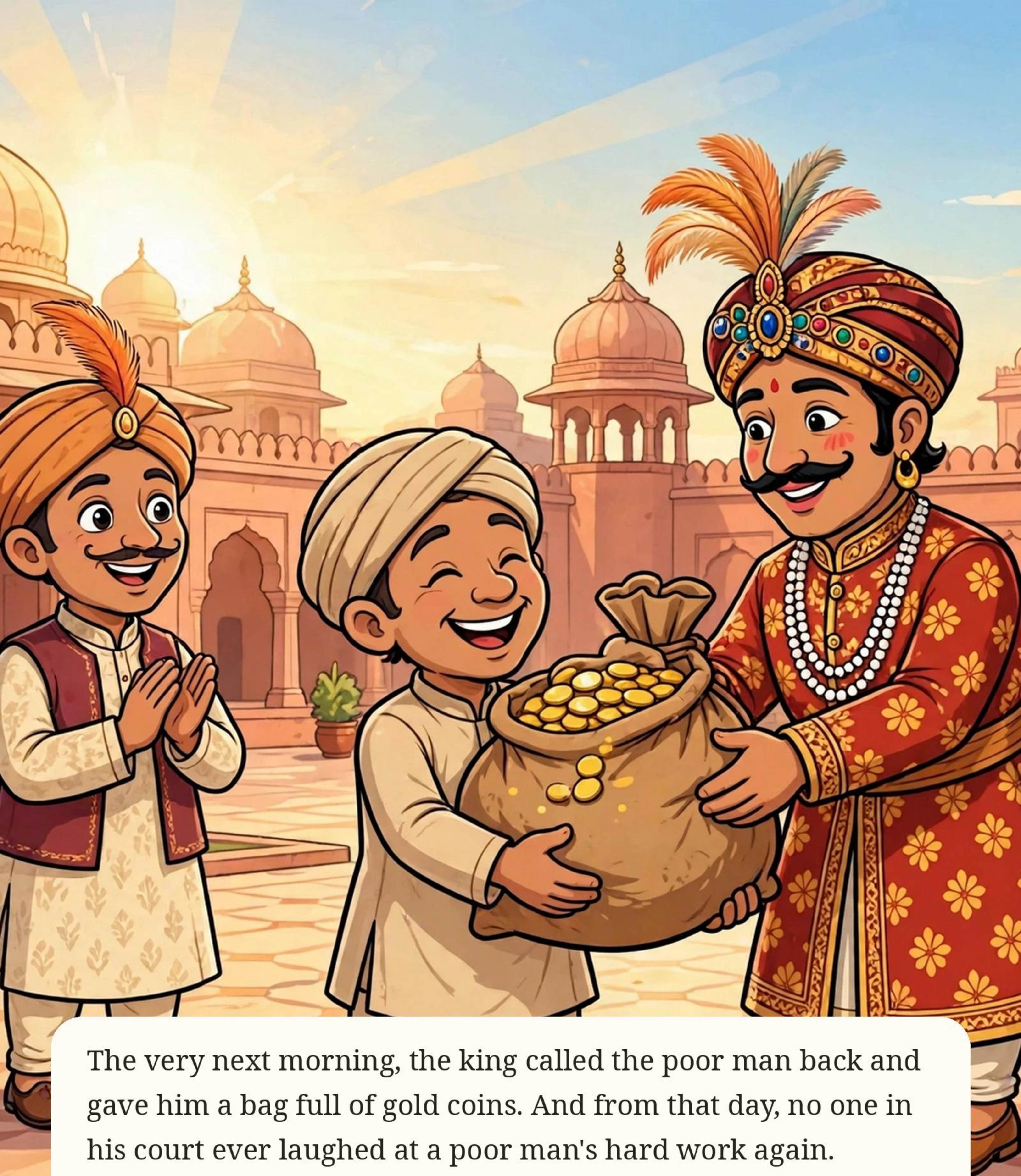
"What are you doing, Birbal?" asked the king, who had come to watch.



"Cooking my dinner, Your Majesty," said Birbal with a smile.
"Just as the faraway lamp warmed the poor man, this faraway
fire will cook my khichdi."



The king laughed — and then he stopped, his face growing red. He understood! If a fire a hundred feet away could not cook khichdi, then a lamp far away could not have warmed the poor man either.



The very next morning, the king called the poor man back and gave him a bag full of gold coins. And from that day, no one in his court ever laughed at a poor man's hard work again.

**True wisdom means understanding
another person's struggle.**

The End

